



WORKFORCE
DATA QUALITY
CAMPAIGN

Non-Degree Credentials of Value

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www.workforcedqc.org

WDQC the data project of National Skills Coalition

WDQC promotes federal and state policies to improve the quality and availability of data that is effectively used to improve our nation's education and workforce strategies.

What are Non-Degree Credentials of Value?

Non-degree credentials are credentials that have value in the labor market, that are not an Associate's or Bachelor's Degree



Common Types of Non-Degree Credentials

- Certificates
- Industry Certifications
- Licenses



Certificates

A credential awarded by an *educational institution* based on completion of all requirements for a program of study, including coursework and tests. They are not time limited and do not need to be renewed.



Industry Certifications



A credential awarded by a certification body (*not* a school or government agency) based on an individual demonstrating, through an *examination process*, that he or she has acquired the designated knowledge, skills, and abilities to perform a specific occupation or skill. It is time-limited and may be renewed through a re-certification process.

Licenses



A credential that permits the holder to practice in a specified field. A license is awarded by a government licensing agency based on pre-determined criteria. The criteria may include some combination of degree attainment, certifications, certificates, assessment, apprenticeship programs or work experience. Licenses are time-limited and must be renewed periodically.

Non-Degree Credentials Are Common

- 27% of adults
- 8% hold a certificate
- More than 600,000 certificates per year
- Growth of certificates
93% at community colleges



Certificates Have Value

- 20% Higher Earnings compared to high school Graduates
- 36% Earn more than median Associate Degrees



Certificates Have Value

- Higher wage certificates: IT electronics, protective services, construction, metal working
- Lower wage certificates: cosmetology, food services
- Wages are higher for related employment

Identifying Credentials of Value

- Identify labor market demand.
- Determine employment outcomes.
- Engage employers.



Career Pathways

- Integrated education and training
- Career counseling
- Support services
- Industry engagement
- Job placement services
- Stackable credentials

Stackable Credentials

An industry-recognized credential offered by a certificate or other non-degree program, or a third-party certification or occupational license, which articulates toward a higher level certificate or associates degree in the same occupational area.

Resources

- “[Certificates: Gateway to Gainful Employment and College Degrees](#),” Carnevale, Rose, Hanson; Georgetown Center on Education and the Workforce, 2012.
- “[Alignment Policy Toolkit](#),” Wilson; National Skills Coalition; 2016.
- “[Stackable Credentials Policy Toolkit](#),” Wilson; National Skills Coalition; 2016.
- [Programs That Work: Quality Assurance for Short-term Occupational Programs](#),” Leventoff, Workforce Data Quality Campaign; 2017.
- <http://connectingcredentials.org/>

Questions





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